game against England, where our bowlers got smashed. We eventually fell 22 runs short of chasing down England's 323. So that's where I was with my batting. All in all, 2009 was a bit of a roller coaster. It started out slowly, then got a whole lot better before tapering off as my opportunities started to dry up. They would dry up completely when, during the Champions Trophy, I got a missed call from the then convener of selectors, Mike Procter.

I had a feeling something was up, so I phoned him back, which is when I found out that I was to be dropped from the squad for the upcoming home series against the Poms.

'Hersch, did you get my message?' Procter asked.

'No, why?' I replied.

'Well, we haven't included you in the ODI squad against England.'

The reason was that I wasn't 'consistent' enough. And Mickey Arthur was questioning my preparation. According to him, I hadn't prepared sufficiently for the Champions Trophy – a statement I found bizarre. I had prepared exactly the same way I have for my whole career, but this time it wasn't good enough? I played one game in that tournament and I mistimed a pull shot off James Anderson's bowling.

'Inconsistent and ill-prepared.'

Whatever. Man, was I pissed off. I had been one of the Proteas' most consistent batsmen in the preceding year – it was only when they started yo-yoing me in and out of the starting XI that I started struggling a little. My confidence was shot. I remember the conversation with Procter was rather curt and ended with me saying, 'Okay, well, if that's your story, bye,' and terminating the call.

As you know, the ODI series against England in November/December 2009 was a disaster. We lost the five-match series 1-2, with both the first and fifth ODIs being abandoned without a ball being bowled. For that final game in Port Elizabeth, I was actually called back into the squad after Jacques Kallis was out injured. Except I was to be twelfth man … which didn't make me a happy chappy at all.

I was thinking a lot about my future with the Proteas at that point. I mean, not since the earliest days of my international career had I been twelfth man. I was always in the starting XI for Tests and ODIs – especially in the ODIs. And especially in PE, where I have a great record. But no … here I was, the bladdy waterboy. Obviously there was some ego involved here, but I seriously began to wonder whether or not I should give up on the